

Vicksburg. The Confederates occupied high ground, but McPherson's corps relentlessly struck their left flank, stunning the defenders. Pemberton's poor tactical leadership made matters worse, and by the end of the day the Confederates were in full retreat. It was a superb tactical victory for Grant's army.

The Big Black River was the last natural barrier before the eastern approaches to Vicksburg. If Grant's army could breach this obstacle, only the formidable Confederate entrenchments around the city would stand between Grant and victory.

On May 17, troops of John A. McClernand's corps, eager to prove their mettle, attacked a strong Confederate position along this last line of defense before the Vicksburg entrenchments. The assault might have failed, but John C. Pemberton left a bridge standing that should have been burned. The Confederates were routed, losing another 1,750 men. In the aftermath of the Battle of Big Black River, the Confederate army could only withdraw to Vicksburg. Civilians in the Southern stronghold were appalled at the condition of Pemberton's men as they dejectedly filed into their positions. One eyewitness summed up their condition as "humanity in the last throes of existence."